

Artists Keep Ancient Japanese Craft Alive

Eiko Araki is an expert of the Sanuki Kagari Temari, a Japanese traditional craft. The craft has been passed down for more than 1,000 years on the island of Shikoku.

Araki is at the center of a small circle of women who are working hard to make “temari.” These balls are small artistic objects that have colorful designs. They can take weeks or months to finish. Some cost hundreds of dollars although others are less costly.

The balls are not for sports. They are created as special objects, carrying prayers for health and goodness. They might be treasured like a painting in a Western home.

“Out of nothing, something this beautiful is born, bringing joy,” said Araki about the temari. “I want it to be remembered there are beautiful things in this world that can only be made by hand.”

FILE - Eiko Araki, second from left, sits and works on the temari with her co-workers at her studio in Kawaramachi, on Sept. 5, 2024. Araki is a master of the Japanese traditional craft of Sanuki Kagari Temari. (AP Photo/Yuri Kageyama)

Creating the balls

The area where temari began was good for growing cotton. The round creations continue to be made out of that material.

At Araki’s studio, which also serves as head office for temari’s preservation society, there are 140 colors of cotton thread.

The women dye them by hand, using plants, flowers and other natural ingredients. Outside the studio, cotton thread, in different colors, hangs outside in the shade to dry.

The lengthy process starts with making the basic ball. The careful work with thread called stitching is done on the ball. The outer covering of rice grains, called husks, are cooked and then dried and placed in a piece of cotton. Then the materials are wound with thread, over and over, until, almost magically, a ball appears.

FILE - Cotton thread used for making the Japanese traditional craft of Sanuki Kagari Temari in Kawaramachi hang to dry in Kawaramachi, on Sept. 5, 2024. (AP Photo/Yuri Kageyama)

Then the stitching begins.

The balls are surprisingly hard, so each stitch requires a careful, almost painful, push.

New generation

These days, temari is getting new recognition among Japanese and foreigners as well. Caroline Kennedy, for example, took lessons in the ball-making when she was United States ambassador to Japan 10 years ago.

Yoshie Nakamura promotes Japanese handcrafted art in her shop at Tokyo's Haneda airport. Nakamura says she features temari there because of its complex designs.

"Temari that might have been everyday in a faraway era is now being used for interior decoration," she said.

"I really feel each Sanuki Kagari Temari speaks of a special, one-and-only existence in the world."

Araki has come up with some newer designs that feel both modern and historical. She is trying to make the balls more available for everyday life. For example, some of the balls can be used to beautify Christmas trees.

Araki often travels to Tokyo to teach. But mostly she works and gives lessons in her studio.

She started out as a metalwork artist. Her husband's parents were temari masters who worked hard to bring back the artform when it was at risk of dying out.

They were not emotional people. They rarely gave praise and instead always scolded her, she remembers. It is a "tough love" teaching method that is common in many Japanese traditional arts, from Kabuki acting to hogaku music. These art forms demand a lifetime of selfless devotion.

FILE - A staff member works on the temari at Sanuki Kagari Temari in Kawaramachi, Kagawa prefecture, Japan, on Sept. 5, 2024. (AP Photo/Ayaka McGill)

Today, only a small number of people, all women, can make the temari balls to traditional standards.

Araki said that the most difficult issue is training the next generation. She added that it usually "takes over 10 years to train them, so you need people who are willing to continue the craft for a very long time."

But, she explained, "When people start to feel joy along with the hardship that comes with making temari, they tend to keep going."

I'm John Russell.

Yuri Kageyama reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

studio - n. สตูดิโอ, ห้องทำงานศิลปะ

preservation - n. การอนุรักษ์, การสงวนรักษา

thread - n. เส้นด้าย

dye - v. ย้อมสี

era - n. ยุค, สมัย

interior decoration - n. การตกแต่งภายใน

scold - v. ดุด่า, ตำหนิอย่างรุนแรง

devotion - n. การอุทิศตน, ความจงรักภักดี

standard - n. มาตรฐาน

tend - v. มีแนวโน้ม, มีความโน้มเอียง

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What information is provided about Sanuki Kagari Temari in the second paragraph?

It is a newly developed craft on the island of Shikoku.

It is a traditional Japanese craft with a history spanning over a millennium.

It is primarily practiced by men in various regions of Japan.

It originated in Tokyo and is a modern art form.

2. According to the third paragraph, which of the following describes 'temari' balls?

They are large, inexpensive sporting equipment.

They are quickly made, monochrome household items.

They are small, artistic objects with colorful designs, requiring significant time to create.

They are industrial products mass-produced for decoration.

3. What is the primary purpose of temari balls, as stated in the text?

To be used as sports equipment in traditional Japanese games.

To serve as a form of currency for trade.

To be cherished as special objects embodying prayers for well-being.

To provide entertainment for children as toys.

4. What sentiment does Eiko Araki express about temari in her quote?

Her desire for temari to become a popular sport.

Her belief that machine-made goods are superior.

Her appreciation for the beauty and joy derived from handmade creations.

Her concern about the declining interest in traditional crafts.

5. What material is mentioned as being traditionally used for temari balls due to its local availability?

Silk

Wool

Cotton

Linen

6. Besides being Araki's studio, what other significant role does her workshop play?

It functions as a retail store for selling temari balls.

It serves as the primary location for textile manufacturing.

It acts as the main office for the temari preservation society.

It is a historical museum dedicated to Japanese crafts.

7. How are the threads for temari balls typically colored?

They are purchased pre-dyed from industrial suppliers.

They are colored using synthetic dyes in a factory.

They are dyed by hand using natural materials like plants and flowers.

They are bleached to achieve a pure white color.

8. What is the initial step in creating the basic temari ball, as described in the text?

Stitching intricate patterns onto the surface.

Winding thread around a pre-made core.

Preparing the core by cooking and drying rice husks and placing them in cotton.

Dyeing the cotton threads in various colors.

9. Which unexpected material forms a part of the core of the temari ball?

Metal filings

Plastic beads

Rice husks

Clay

10. What characteristic of the temari balls makes the stitching process challenging?

Their delicate and fragile nature.

Their extremely soft texture.

Their surprising hardness.

Their sticky surface.

11. Who is mentioned as an example of a foreigner showing interest in temari?

Eiko Araki

Yoshie Nakamura

Caroline Kennedy

Yuri Kageyama

12. Why does Yoshie Nakamura feature temari in her shop at Tokyo's Haneda airport?

Because they are inexpensive souvenirs for tourists.

Due to their simple and minimalist aesthetic.

For their intricate and complex designs.

As a demonstration of modern art techniques.

13. According to Yoshie Nakamura, how has the use of temari evolved from a 'faraway era' to the present?

It has shifted from being a decorative item to sports equipment.

It has transitioned from everyday use to being primarily for interior decoration.

It has become a symbol of political power.

It is now exclusively used in religious ceremonies.

14. What is Eiko Araki doing to make temari more relevant for modern life?

She is strictly adhering to traditional designs only.

She is making them exclusively for museum exhibits.

She is introducing newer designs and suggesting their use for everyday items like Christmas trees.

She is reducing their production to increase their rarity.

15. What does Araki identify as the most significant challenge in ensuring the future of temari?

Lack of interest from foreign tourists.

The high cost of materials.

The difficulty and lengthy time required to train the next generation of artisans.

The decline in demand for handmade crafts.